

ZARDARI MISCALCULATED THE EFFECT OF SHARIFS' DISQUALIFICATION.

the PPP and Awami National Party agreed to a "peace agreement" brokered by hardline Islamist Maulana Sufi Mohammad. The ceasefire is shaky and Sufi is already accusing the Government of reneging on its promises. A couple of attacks on the military by Tehrik-e-Taliban have also vitiated the atmosphere. If the shaky truce collapses—and there are ample signs it will—there is no telling how much bloodshed will follow.

The situation in the Federally Administered Tribal Areas (FATA) has long been a source of worry for the US and Pakistan. America increasingly feels that Al Qaeda-linked militants are helping Afghan insurgents set up safe havens and has not hesitated in attacking targets through its unmanned Predator drones. This, in turn, is feeding anti-American feeling in the area, making anti-militant operations difficult. The discovery that the Predator drones are actually flying out of Pakistani airstrips has also seriously embarrassed the Government and exposed its policy of protesting against the attacks for domestic consumption.

The lawyers' movement for the restoration of the judiciary sacked by General Musharraf on November 3, 2007, had been stripped of much of its passion by the desertion from its ranks of the PPP-backed lawyers and the acceptance of a compromise reappointment by most of the sacked judges. The issue of a full reinstatement had, however, continued to fester, especially since the symbol of the movement, former Chief Justice Iftikhar Chaudhry, still continued to be out in the cold, primarily because, his supporters feel, President Asif Zardari feels personally threatened by him. In

addition, the personal scandals around sitting Chief Justice A.H. Dogar, who allegedly went out of his way to get his daughter an undeserved seat in college and who is also due to retire by March 21, had made him widely reviled. The announcement by

PML(N)—had reluctantly endorsed the lawyers' sit-in earlier. Now, they squarely accused Zardari of being behind the Supreme Court ruling and claimed they had been offered relief in the courts if they gave up support to the lawyers' movement. With the

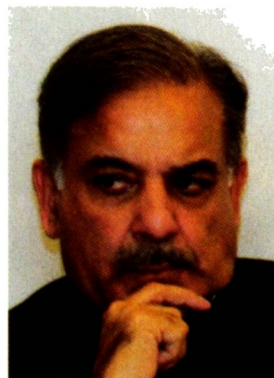
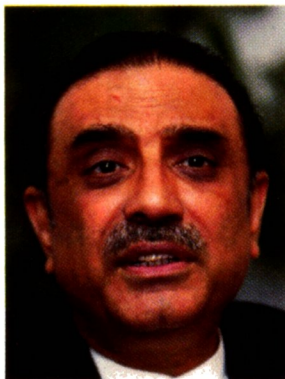
intensity of the PML(N)'s personal attacks on the President increasing, and with Zardari clearly backing moves to form a PPP government in the Punjab despite the PML(N)'s superior numbers, the polarisation especially in Pakistan's most populous province has reached enormous heights.

President Zardari had clearly miscalculated the effect the Sharifs' disqualification would have on the political scene. Ironically, even as the PPP consolidates its power—it has predictably emerged as the largest party in the Senate after the polls for the Upper House on March 3—it is fast losing the moral high ground and the whispers of a political upheaval are gaining strength. Aiding these whispers is the apparent resentment within the PPP ranks itself of

Zardari's autocratic methods and the power enjoyed by a select few close to him at the expense of the real Cabinet.

Daniel Markey, senior fellow at the American Council on Foreign Relations, wrote in an article on March 2 that Pakistan's Government had "gone to war with itself" and warned that "destabilising violence and prolonged political uncertainty" could convince the army to intervene again. Tellingly, he advised US President Obama to "prepare for that unwelcome contingency by formulating a list of its highest-priority demands for any new military regime".

March was always going to be a cruel month. ■



(CLOCKWISE FROM ABOVE RIGHT)
SHAHBAZ AND NAWAZ SHARIF,
ZARDARI AND GENERAL PARVEZ KAYANI

the lawyers of a "long march" on March 12 and a sit-in in front of Parliament to make a final push for their cause helped re-galvanise their rank and file. There are signs of nervousness in the Government about the chaos the "long march" could plunge Islamabad into.

In the middle of all this came the Supreme Court ruling which barred the main opposition leaders, Nawaz Sharif and his brother Shahbaz, from holding public office. The Sharifs' Pakistan Muslim League (Nawaz)—